Phosphorus comes from the Greek for “light-bearing,” and was the ancient name for the planet Venus when it appeared before sunrise in the dawn sky.

Selenium comes from *selene*, which is Greek for the Moon, named so because in ores, it was always associated with the element tellurium, which had already been named for Earth, from the Latin *tellus*.

On January 1, 1801, the Italian astronomer Giuseppe Piazzi discovered a new planet orbiting the Sun in the suspiciously large gap between Mars and Jupiter. Keeping with the tradition of naming planets after Roman gods, the object was named Ceres, after the goddess of harvest. Ceres is, of course, the root of the word “cereal.” At the time, there was sufficient excitement in the scientific community for the first element to be discovered after this date to be named cerium in its honor. Two years later, another planet was discovered, orbiting the Sun in the same gap as Ceres. This one was named Pallas, for the Roman goddess of wisdom, and, like cerium before it, the first element discovered thereafter was named palladium in its honor. The naming party would end a few decades later. After dozens more of these planets were discovered sharing the same orbital zone, closer analysis revealed that these objects were much, much smaller than the smallest known planets. A new swath of real estate had been discovered in the solar system, populated by small, craggy chunks of rock and metal. Ceres and Pallas were not planets; they are asteroids, and they live in the asteroid belt, now known to contain hundreds of thousands of objects—somewhat more than the number of elements in the Periodic Table.

The metal mercury, liquid and runny at room temperature, and the planet Mercury, the fastest of all planets in the solar system, are both named for the speedy Roman messenger god of the same name.

Thorium is named for Thor, the hunky, lightning bolt–wielding Scandinavian god, who corresponds with lightning bolt–wielding Jupiter in Roman mythology. And by Jove, Hubble Space Telescope images of Jupiter’s polar regions reveal extensive electrical discharges deep within its turbulent cloud layers.

Alas, Saturn, my favorite planet,[††] has no element named for it, but Uranus, Neptune, and Pluto are famously represented. The element uranium was discovered in 1789 and named in honor of the planet discovered by William Herschel just eight years earlier. All isotopes of uranium are unstable, spontaneously decaying to lighter elements, a process accompanied by the release of energy. The first atomic bomb ever used in warfare had uranium as its active ingredient, and was